# The Porch Test: Round 1 Grading

38 criteria across 10 items, from round1_grading.xlsx as last saved. Scores already entered are filled in. Copy your paper scores back into the kyle_score column.

| Score | Meaning |
|---|---|
| 2 | Met clearly. |
| 1 | Partly met, or met but stated with an error that matters less than the point. |
| 0 | Missing, wrong, or contradicted elsewhere in the answer. |

Hedging both ways is not a pass. Score the answer's final position: a clearly marked self-correction is not a contradiction. Judge substance only, not length, tone or formatting.

## 1. T2-001 sophisms

QUESTION

Explain the Sorites (the heap) as the Stoics knew it, and how Chrysippus responded to it.

GOLD ANSWER

> The Sorites chains small steps: if two is few, three is few; if three is few, four is few; and so on, so that if two is few, ten (or any number) is few. Each step seems undeniable, yet the conclusion seems false. Chrysippus's response, as Cicero reports it, was not to find a flaw in the form but to stop: when questioned step by step, he would 'rest' or fall silent before reaching the doubtful cases, withholding assent. The problem lies in assent to the premises, not in the logic of the chain.

MODEL ANSWER

**The Sorites and Chrysippus' Response**

**The puzzle**

The name comes from Greek *soros*, "heap." The puzzle is traditionally traced to the Megarian logician Eubulides of Miletus (4th century BCE), who also gave us the Liar and the Hooded Man. It runs:

1. One grain of wheat is not a heap.
2. If *n* grains are not a heap, then *n* + 1 grains are not a heap. A single grain cannot make the difference.
3. So 10,000 grains are not a heap.

It can also run in reverse. Ten thousand grains are a heap, and removing one grain from a heap leaves a heap, so a single grain is a heap. The same pattern works with "few" and "many," "rich" and "poor," "bald" and "hairy." Each step seems unobjectionable, and the conclusion is absurd.

**Why it mattered to the Stoics**

For the Stoics the puzzle was a serious threat, not just a curiosity.

- **Bivalence.** Stoic logic held that every proposition is true or false. If "100 grains is a heap" is true and "1 grain is a heap" is false, there must be a sharp boundary somewhere.
- **Epistemology.** The Stoics said the sage assents only to "cognitive" (*katalēptic*) impressions and never holds mere opinion. The Academic skeptics, especially Arcesilaus and Carneades, used sorites arguments to claim that

impressions shade into one another without a definite break, so no impression can be reliably marked off as cognitive.
- **Ethics.** The Stoics held that a person is either wise or foolish, with nothing in between. A sorites-style argument asks what happens when someone makes gradual moral progress.

**Chrysippus' response**

Chrysippus wrote on the sorites (Diogenes Laertius lists several works), but our evidence is fragmentary and comes mostly from hostile sources: Cicero's *Academica*, Sextus Empiricus, Plutarch, and Galen. The main points are these.

**1. Do not accept the universal conditional.** He treated the argument as a sophism with a false premise. The Stoics read the major premise as a negated conjunction ("it is not the case that both *n* grains are not a heap and *n* + 1 grains are a heap"), and Chrysippus held that this is false somewhere. There is a last number that is not a heap and a next one that is. Since the Stoics accepted bivalence, there must be a cut-off.

**2. We cannot know where the cut-off is.** In the borderline region the impressions are not clear, and no cognitive grasp is possible. Chrysippus therefore advised stopping and suspending assent when the questioning enters the obscure zone. Cicero reports this as the advice to "stop" or "keep quiet" (*quiescere*, *hēsychazein* in Greek). Plutarch mentions it too.

**3. Silence is a strategy, not a concession.** The point is to refuse to be drawn into answering questions one cannot answer reliably, not to claim that there is no boundary. Chrysippus applied the same idea to moral progress. Someone may be one step from wisdom without being able to tell.

**Objections**

Carneades pressed the obvious objection, as Cicero reports. Falling silent does not help, because the questioner can simply continue, or wait until you are "awake" and ask again. Silence does not answer the question and does not stop the series of questions. Chrysippus could reply that he was concerned with the sage's assent, not with escaping every question, but critics found this unsatisfying.

**Modern interpretation**

Scholars disagree on how to read Chrysippus. Some, notably Susanne Bobzien, see him as an early **epistemicist**: vagueness is ignorance, and there is a sharp but unknowable boundary. Others think the evidence is too thin for that and read his advice as a more practical dialectical rule. Either way, he anticipated one of the main positions in the modern debate.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 1 | Describes the stepwise structure of the argument correctly | 2 | |
| 2 | 2 | Reports Chrysippus's response as resting or falling silent (withholding assent) before the doubtful cases | 2 | |
| 3 | 3 | Locates the difficulty in assent to the premises rather than in an invalid form | | |
| 4 | 4 | Does not attribute a modern solution (such as fuzzy logic or supervaluation) to Chrysippus as his own view without flagging it as a modern interpretation | | |

## 2. T1-008 stoic_logic

QUESTION

Consider: "'It is both day and night' is false; it is day; therefore it is not night." Is this valid in Stoic logic? Is it a syllogism in the Stoic sense?

GOLD ANSWER

> It is conclusive (valid), but the Stoics did not count it as syllogistic. Diogenes Laertius gives it as an example of an argument that is conclusive in the specific sense: it draws its conclusion, but not by syllogism. The major premise asserts that a conjunction is false rather than negating the conjunction, so it is not a third indemonstrable and cannot be reduced to one.

MODEL ANSWER

**Yes on both counts.** The argument is valid in Stoic logic, and it is a syllogism in the Stoic sense. It is also one of the five basic argument forms, the third indemonstrable.

**The form**

Chrysippus' third indemonstrable (*anapodeiktos*) is:

> Not both the first and the second; the first; therefore, not the second.

Sextus Empiricus gives almost exactly your example: "Not: it is day and it is night; but it is day; therefore it is not night."

Your argument fits this form with: - first = "It is day" - second = "It is night"

**Why it is valid**

The Stoics counted an argument as valid when the conjunction of its premises together with the contradictory of its conclusion is incompatible. Here the premises are "not (day and night)" and "day", and the contradictory of the conclusion is "it is night". These three cannot all be true, so the argument is valid. The Stoics treated this form as self-evident and needing no proof.

**Why it is a syllogism in the Stoic sense**

Stoic "syllogism" differs from Aristotelian syllogism in three ways:

1. **Propositional, not term-based.** Stoic syllogisms are built from whole propositions (*axiomata*), not from terms like "All A are B." Day and night here are complete propositions.
2. **Premises and conclusion.** A Stoic argument has a leading premise (*lemma*), an assumed premise (*proslepsis*), and a conclusion (*epiphora*). In your argument the leading premise is the negated conjunction, the assumption is "it is day", and the conclusion is "it is not night".
3. **Indemonstrables.** The Stoics called valid arguments "syllogistic" when they were either indemonstrable or reducible to the indemonstrables by the *themata* (rules like the dialectical "cut" rule). Yours is itself indemonstrable, so no reduction is needed.

**A point about the negated conjunction**

The Stoics were careful to negate a conjunction by prefixing "not" to the whole, as in "Not: both A and B". This avoids the ambiguity of putting the negation inside one of the conjuncts. Your phrasing, "'It is both day and night' is false", does this correctly.

**Comparison with the disjunctive form**

The fifth indemonstrable ("Either the first or the second; the first; therefore not the second") reaches the same conclusion from an exclusive disjunction. The Stoic disjunction is stronger than the negated conjunction, since it also says that one of the two must hold. The third indemonstrable needs only the weaker premise that they cannot both be true, so it is the natural form for your argument.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | 1 | States that the argument is valid (conclusive) | | |
| 6 | 2 | States that the Stoics did not count it as syllogistic | | |
| 7 | 3 | Explains that saying a conjunction 'is false' differs from negating it, so the third indemonstrable does not apply | | |
| 8 | 4 | Does not simply call it a third indemonstrable | | |

## 3. T2-002 sophisms

QUESTION

"If anyone is here, he is not in Rhodes; someone is here; therefore no one is in Rhodes." This looks like a first indemonstrable. Is it a valid Stoic syllogism?

GOLD ANSWER

> No. This is the Stoic 'Nobody' argument, listed by Diogenes Laertius among the insoluble arguments, and it is a sophism. It only looks like a first indemonstrable. The major premise mixes an indefinite clause ('anyone') with a definite one, and the argument trades on that: the indefinite 'anyone' in the premise does not license the universal 'no one' in the conclusion. Its fault is an equivocation that propositional form cannot capture.

MODEL ANSWER

**No. It only looks like a first indemonstrable (modus ponens), and the Stoics would not count it as a valid instance.**

**The apparent form.** A first indemonstrable has the shape:

> If the first, then the second; the first; therefore the second.

Here that would be: "If someone is here, he is not in Rhodes; someone is here; therefore no one is in Rhodes."

**Why it fails.**

1. **The conclusion is not the consequent.** In a genuine first indemonstrable, the conclusion must be the very consequent of the conditional. The consequent here is "he is not in Rhodes," where "he" is an anaphoric pronoun tied to the indefinite "someone." The conclusion is instead "no one is in Rhodes," a different and much stronger proposition. The surface similarity of the wording hides this.

2. **Indefinite versus definite propositions.** The Stoics distinguished definite propositions ("*this* man is here"), which have a demonstrative and a determinate truth value, from indefinite ones ("someone is here"). The first premise is really a general claim: for anything, if it is here, it is not in Rhodes. The second premise is existential. From these, the most you can derive is that the particular person who is here is not in Rhodes. Modus ponens works properly only on a definite instance: "If *this one* is here, *this one* is not in Rhodes; *this one* is here; therefore *this one* is not in Rhodes."

3. **Countermodel.** Suppose Dion is here in Athens and Theon is in Rhodes. The first premise is true, since no one who is here is in Rhodes. The second premise is true, since someone is here. The conclusion is false, since Theon is in Rhodes. True premises and a false conclusion make the argument invalid. This is also the Stoic test: a valid argument is one whose premises' conjunction, joined to the negation of the conclusion, is incoherent.

**Diagnosis.** The argument is a non sequitur that trades on an equivocation. The "someone" and "he" of the first premise are treated as if they were the same as the unrestricted "no one" of the conclusion. It resembles a valid schema but is not one.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 9 | 1 | States that the argument is not a valid syllogism | | |
| 10 | 2 | Identifies it as the 'Nobody' (Outis) sophism or otherwise recognizes it as a known Stoic sophism | | |
| 11 | 3 | Locates the fault in the indefinite expressions ('anyone', 'someone', 'no one'), not in the first indemonstrable's form | | |
| 12 | 4 | Does not classify it as a first indemonstrable | | |

## 4. T3-004 doctrine

QUESTION

If the Stoics believed everything happens by fate, how could Chrysippus say we are responsible for our actions?

GOLD ANSWER

> Chrysippus distinguished kinds of causes. An external impression is an auxiliary and proximate cause that sets things going, but how we respond depends on our own nature and character, the perfect and principal cause. His image is the cylinder (Cicero pairs it with a spinning top): you push it to start it rolling, but it rolls the way it does because of its own shape. In the same way, impressions start our responses, but our assent comes from us, so we are responsible for it even within a fated world. This is a compatibilist position, and whether it succeeds was disputed in antiquity and still is.

MODEL ANSWER

Chrysippus defended a form of compatibilism: fate and responsibility are consistent because fate works *through* our own natures and choices rather than around them.

**1. The cylinder and cone analogy** Our main source is Cicero (*On Fate*) and Aulus Gellius. Pushing a cylinder and a cone both start them moving, but the cylinder rolls and the cone wobbles in a circle, each according to its shape. The push is an external, antecedent cause, but how the object moves depends on its own nature. Likewise, external impressions prompt us, but what we do with them depends on our character, which is the proximate cause of the action. Since the action comes from who we are, it's ours.

**2. Assent as the locus of responsibility** Impressions arrive involuntarily, but the Stoics held that we must *assent* to them (*synkatathesis*) before acting. Assent is an act of our rational faculty. Fate may determine the whole causal history, but the assent is still the agent's own act, and it's what makes the action voluntary and attributable to us.

**3. Fate isn't the same as external compulsion** Compulsion means being forced against your own impulses. In a fated action, your own desires and judgments are part of the causal chain. The later Stoic image of a dog tied to a cart makes the point: the dog can run along willingly or be dragged. Either way it goes where the cart goes, but only in the first case is it acting in harmony with its fate. For the Stoics, virtue lies in that kind of willing alignment.

**4. Praise and blame stay meaningful** Because actions flow from character, we can still evaluate agents for the quality of their characters and judgments. Praise, blame, education, and punishment are themselves part of the causal order, and they shape people's dispositions. They aren't made pointless by determinism.

**5. Against the "Lazy Argument"** The objection runs: if it's fated that you'll recover from illness, you'll recover whether or not you call a doctor, so why bother? Chrysippus replied that some events are "co-fated." Your recovery is fated *together with* your calling the doctor, so you can't get the one without the other. Fate includes our efforts among its causes.

**Criticisms** - Ancient critics such as Alexander of Aphrodisias argued that this isn't real freedom, since given the prior causes, no alternative was possible. - Cicero suggests Chrysippus was trying to "steer a middle course" between determinism and free will. - Our sources are largely hostile or fragmentary, since Chrysippus's own works are lost, so we're reconstructing his view from opponents and summaries.

In short, Chrysippus redefined responsibility so that it requires that an action come from the agent's own rational assent and character, not that the agent could have done otherwise in an absolute sense.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 13 | 1 | Explains the distinction between the external (proximate, auxiliary) cause and the agent's own nature or assent (principal cause) | | |
| 14 | 2 | Gives the cylinder (or spinning top) analogy correctly | | |
| 15 | 3 | Locates responsibility in assent | | |
| 16 | 4 | Notes that the success of the position was or is disputed, rather than presenting it as settled | | |

## 5. T3-001 doctrine

QUESTION

Did the Stoics teach that we should suppress all emotion?

GOLD ANSWER

> No. The Stoics aimed at freedom from the passions (pathe), which they understood as excessive impulses resting on false judgments about what is good or bad. They did not aim at feeling nothing. The sage has good feelings (eupatheiai): joy, caution and wishing, which are rational counterparts of pleasure, fear and desire (there is no good counterpart of distress). Seneca also allows for involuntary first movements, such as a start of fear, which are not yet passions because no assent has been given.

MODEL ANSWER

No, that's a common misconception, though the reality is more nuanced than "Stoics loved feelings."

**What the Stoics actually targeted**

They distinguished between *pathē* (often translated "passions") and other emotional responses. Pathē were, in their view, excessive or irrational impulses resulting from false judgments, such as believing that wealth, reputation, or even other people's behavior is truly good or bad for us. The four main categories were:

- Distress (grief, anxiety over perceived present evils)
- Fear (anticipated evils)
- Craving (desire for perceived future goods)
- Pleasure (in the sense of excited elation over perceived present goods)

The goal was to eliminate these *judgment-driven* disturbances, not to become numb.

**What they kept**

- **Eupatheiai ("good feelings")**: Stoics endorsed rational emotional states like joy (as opposed to giddy pleasure), caution (as opposed to fear), and rational wishing (as opposed to craving). The sage would experience these.
- **Natural affection**: Family love and care for others were considered appropriate and even obligatory. Epictetus and Marcus Aurelius both stress duties to family and community.
- **Pre-emotions (propatheiai)**: Involuntary reactions like flinching, blushing, turning pale, or initial tears were seen as natural and not blameworthy. Seneca discusses these. What matters is whether you *assent* to the impression that something terrible has happened.

**Where the misconception has some basis**

- Stoics did believe the ideal sage would be free of passions like anger and grief, which sounds austere to many people.
- Some passages, like Epictetus telling you to remind yourself, when kissing your child, that they're mortal, can read as cold, though the intent was to prepare for loss, not to love less.
- Seneca, in his consolation letters, argues against excessive mourning but acknowledges tears are natural. He criticizes both stony indifference and endless lamentation.

**The bottom line**

Stoicism aimed at emotional *regulation through reasoned judgment*, not suppression. Suppression would actually conflict with their view, since they thought the problem lay in the underlying beliefs, not in feelings that needed to be bottled up.

Whether their psychology is fully persuasive is debatable, but "repress everything" isn't what they taught.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 17 | 1 | Says no: the goal is freedom from passions, not from all feeling | | |
| 18 | 2 | Explains passions as resting on false judgments (or excessive impulses), not as feelings in general | | |
| 19 | 3 | Mentions the good feelings (eupatheiai) or names at least two of them (joy, caution, wishing) | | |
| 20 | 4 | Does not equate Stoicism with emotional suppression or 'not caring' | | |

## 6. T5-002 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Did Seneca really say "We suffer more often in imagination than in reality"? If so, where?

GOLD ANSWER

> Yes, that is a fair translation of Seneca, Letters to Lucilius 13.4: 'There are more things likely to frighten us than there are to crush us; we suffer more often in imagination than in reality.' The exact English wording varies by translator.

MODEL ANSWER

Yes, it's genuine. The line comes from Seneca's *Epistulae Morales* (Letters to Lucilius), **Letter 13, section 4**.

**Latin:** *"Plura sunt, Lucili, quae nos terrent quam quae premunt, et saepius opinione quam re laboramus."*

**Gummere's Loeb translation:** "There are more things, Lucilius, likely to frighten us than there are to crush us; we suffer more often in imagination than in reality."

The quote is a fair rendering, though a fairly free one. *Opinione* literally means "by opinion" or "by belief," so a more literal version would be "we labor more often from opinion (our judgment of things) than from reality." "Imagination" captures the sense but is Gummere's wording, and other translators vary.

In the letter, Seneca is advising Lucilius not to torment himself with anticipated misfortunes that may never happen. A related passage a few sections later (13.10) makes a similar point: "Some things torment us more than they ought; some torment us before they ought; and some torment us when they ought not to torment us at all. We are in the habit of exaggerating, or imagining, or anticipating, sorrow."

Because the English wording depends on the translator, you may see slightly different versions attributed to him online. The Latin and the location are solid.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 21 | 1 | Confirms that the quote is genuinely Seneca's | | |
| 22 | 2 | Locates it in Letter 13 (section 4) to Lucilius | | |
| 23 | 3 | Notes that the English wording depends on the translation | | |

## 7. T4-003 applied_ethics

QUESTION

My grandmother died last month. Does Stoicism say I shouldn't grieve?

GOLD ANSWER

> No, not in the cold sense people imagine. Seneca, writing to a grieving friend, allows tears; what he warns against is grief that is excessive, prolonged or performed, and he admits he once wept too much himself. The Stoics distinguish involuntary first movements, which no one can avoid, from the judgment that a terrible evil has happened, which is where passion begins. They also urge remembering the person with gratitude for the time you had, rather than only as a loss.

MODEL ANSWER

I'm sorry about your grandmother. A month is very recent.

No, Stoicism doesn't say you shouldn't grieve, though its reputation as "suppress your feelings" makes it easy to think so.

**What the Stoics said** - **Seneca** wrote in his letter on grief: *"Let not the eyes be dry when we have lost a friend, nor let them overflow. We may weep, but we must not wail."* He thought tears were natural and that grief becomes a problem only when it consumes you or becomes a performance. - **Marcus Aurelius** wept openly when his beloved tutor died. When court officials criticized him for it, his adoptive father, the emperor Antoninus Pius, said: *"Let him be human. Neither philosophy nor empire takes away natural feeling."* - Stoics recognized **involuntary first reactions**, such as tears, a sinking chest, and a lump in the throat. These are not failures of philosophy but part of being human. The Stoic work lies in what you do with your judgments afterward, such as "this is a catastrophe that should never have happened."

**What Stoicism offers** - **Gratitude over deprivation.** Instead of focusing only on the loss, you can see her life as something you were lucky to share in. - **Acceptance of mortality.** Loss is part of the human condition, not a cosmic injustice aimed at you. - **Her influence continues.** Her love, values, and memory remain yours.

Epictetus is the harshest of the Stoics, but even he says to sympathize with those who grieve and not be cold.

Stoicism is a tool, not a rule you can fail at. If you find comfort in it, good. If it feels like pressure to "handle this better," set that part aside. Grief that's allowed to run its course is not unstoic.

How are you doing? Were you close to her?

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 24 | 1 | Says Stoicism does not forbid grief or tears | | |
| 25 | 2 | Cites or accurately describes Seneca's view that tears are natural but excessive grief is to be avoided | | |
| 26 | 3 | Mentions remembering the dead with gratitude, or the distinction between first movements and passion | | |
| 27 | 4 | Does not claim the Stoic ideal is to feel nothing at a death | | |

## 8. T5-001 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Where in the Meditations does Marcus Aurelius say: "Live a good life. If there are gods and they are just, then they will not care how devout you have been, but will welcome you based on the virtues you have lived by"? Give me the book and section.

GOLD ANSWER

> It isn't in the Meditations. This quote is widely attributed to Marcus Aurelius online, but it does not appear in the text. It seems to be a modern composition, perhaps loosely inspired by passages where Marcus considers whether or not the gods exist (for example in Book 2). I can't give a book and section because there isn't one.

MODEL ANSWER

That passage isn't in the *Meditations*. It's a popular internet quote misattributed to Marcus Aurelius. The longer version usually continues with something like "If there are gods, but unjust, then you should not want to worship them. If there are no gods, then you will be gone..." I can't find it in any translation of the *Meditations* or any other ancient source, and the modern phrasing and tone don't match his style.

A few genuine passages touch on similar themes:

- **Book 2, section 11**: Marcus reflects that if the gods exist, they have given us the power to avoid real evils. If they don't exist or don't care, there's little point in worrying about it, and we should still live by reason and virtue.
- **Book 12, section 5**: He discusses how the gods, who are good and just, have arranged things so that virtue is within our power.
- **Book 6, section 44** and related passages: These express his general attitude of accepting providence or nature (or atoms, if that's how things are) while focusing on one's own conduct.

Section numbering varies a little between translations (Hays, Long, Hard, etc.), so check the passage in your edition. If you saw the quote cited as being from the *Meditations*, the source was likely one of the many quote sites that attribute it without evidence.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 28 | 1 | States that the quote does not appear in the Meditations | | |
| 29 | 2 | Does not invent a book and section number | | |
| 30 | 3 | Notes that it is a common misattribution, or offers a genuine related passage clearly marked as different | | |

## 9. T1-005 stoic_logic

QUESTION

"Either it is day or it is night; it is not night; therefore it is day." Which Stoic indemonstrable is this?

GOLD ANSWER

> The fifth indemonstrable: a disjunction, the contradictory of one disjunct, and as conclusion the other disjunct. It is valid.

MODEL ANSWER

This is the **third Stoic indemonstrable**... wait, let me check carefully which one it is.

The five Stoic indemonstrables (Chrysippus):

1. If the first, then the second; the first; therefore the second (modus ponens).
2. If the first, then the second; not the second; therefore not the first (modus tollens).
3. Not both the first and the second; the first; therefore not the second.
4. Either the first or the second; the first; therefore not the second (exclusive disjunction).
5. Either the first or the second; not the second; therefore the first.

The argument "Either it is day or it is night; it is not night; therefore it is day" has the form: *Either A or B; not B; therefore A.*

This is the **fifth indemonstrable**, a disjunctive syllogism: the Stoic "or" is exclusive, and from the disjunction plus the denial of one disjunct, the other follows.

(The fourth indemonstrable would be, e.g., "Either it is day or it is night; it is day; therefore it is not night.")

Answer: **the fifth indemonstrable**.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 31 | 1 | Identifies it as the fifth indemonstrable | | |
| 32 | 2 | States that it is valid | | |
| 33 | 3 | Does not confuse it with the fourth indemonstrable (which affirms a disjunct and denies the other) | | |

## 10. T4-001 applied_ethics

QUESTION

I might be laid off in the next few months. What would Epictetus say is up to me here, and what should I actually do?

GOLD ANSWER

> Epictetus would separate what is up to you (your judgments, choices, desires and efforts) from what is not (the company's decision, the job market, your reputation). The layoff itself is not up to you, and for a Stoic losing the job would not be an evil, only the loss of a preferred indifferent. But that does not mean doing nothing. What is up to you is acting well: preparing, applying, doing your current work honestly, and caring for the people who depend on you, while holding the outcome lightly, aiming at it 'if nothing prevents'. The harm to guard against is the judgment that this would ruin you, not the event.

MODEL ANSWER

**What Epictetus would say**

**The dichotomy of control:** Some things are "up to us" (our judgments, intentions, and actions), and others are not (our body, reputation, property, and other people's decisions).

**Not up to you:** - Whether the layoff happens - The company's finances and leadership's decisions - Whether you're selected - The job market you'll land in - What others think of you if it happens

**Up to you:** - How you interpret the situation (a catastrophe, or a hard event you can work with?) - The quality of your work and conduct while you're still there - How you prepare - How you treat people, including those making the decisions - What you do with the aftermath

Epictetus's core claim is that it's not events that disturb us but our judgments about them. "I'll be laid off, and that would be terrible" is a judgment layered on top of the fact. The fact is "I might lose this job." Whether it's a disaster depends partly on what you tell yourself and what you've done to prepare.

**What to do**

Stoicism isn't passive acceptance. Prepare for what's in your control.

**1. Practice *premeditatio malorum* (negative visualization).** Spend a little time concretely imagining the layoff: the conversation, the first week, the money. Then ask what you would do. This usually shrinks the fear, because vague dread turns into a manageable problem.

**2. Do the practical prep now.** - Calculate your runway: savings, severance you might expect, expenses you could cut, and unemployment benefits where you live. - Update your resume and LinkedIn quietly. - Reconnect with your network now, not after the announcement. Coffee chats don't have to signal anything. - Save records of your accomplishments, and copies of anything you're entitled to keep, such as performance reviews and contact info for colleagues. Don't take proprietary materials. - Look at the benefits situation, such as health insurance, and at what a severance negotiation might involve. - Start casually looking at openings, or at skills worth building.

**3. Keep acting well at work.** Not out of anxiety or to "save" your job, which you can't control, but because doing good work is its own standard. It also protects your reputation and references.

**4. Limit rumination.** Check the news and gossip less. Ask whether a given worry leads to an action. If it does, schedule the action. If not, practice letting it go.

**5. Prepare emotionally, not just logistically.** Tell a few trusted people. Keep routines like sleep, exercise, and time with others. Epictetus would count these as part of looking after your capacity to act well.

**A caution**

Stoicism is sometimes misread as "don't feel anything." Epictetus isn't saying you shouldn't be anxious or upset. He's saying you can examine those impressions rather than being carried off by them. Concern about money and the future is reasonable, and it's useful to the extent it prompts preparation.

If you'd like, tell me your situation (industry, savings cushion, how likely the layoff seems), and I can help you build a more specific plan.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

| Row | # | Criterion | Score | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 34 | 1 | Correctly sorts what is up to the person (judgments, choices, efforts) from what is not (the decision, the market) | | |
| 35 | 2 | Treats the job as an indifferent (or preferred indifferent), not as a good whose loss is an evil | | |
| 36 | 3 | Recommends active, sensible effort rather than passivity or resignation | | |
| 37 | 4 | Locates the real threat in the person's judgments about the event | | |
| 38 | 5 | Does not advise the person to stop caring about their family or obligations | | |